



People Ops Team,

When I first heard about the Senior Rails Programmer role⁴ I started sharing it within my peers, our local Ruby Brigade², and the Junior Rails Programmer⁵ role with the instructor of the Programming & Software Development⁶ program at the local Career Center. I am an alumni of the Carpentry program at the Career Center and I am currently one of the members of the Advisory Committee and a Work Placement Mentor for the Programming & Software Development program. Working at 37Signals would be a great opportunity to grow professionally, open the doors to a deeper learning of, opportunities for collaborating on, and contributing to the Ruby on Rails framework that has helped me enjoy and succeed in my career. I cannot think of a better way to give back to the community that has supported me, while also improving my ability to help future developers, than by working with the team that created and is maintaining Ruby on Rails. Because of this, I feel compelled to take a shot on goal²⁸ and lead by example in recognizing and making the most of this opportunity.

I have a non-traditional career path that has lead me to have very unique experiences with problem solving and efficiency. Initially my calling was to be an Interior Trim Carpenter. Immediately after high school, I ran my own business, trimming entire 5000+ sqft homes on my own. Through the power of decomposition, jigs and learning from previous experiences, I was able to be faster, have a higher quality and charge less than most crews. I started teaching myself HTML and CSS to build a website for my business. However, I needed to leave the industry after I developed allergies to the woods I was working with.

I left carpentry and joined the US Navy as a Reactor Chemist on Submarines, where I was responsible for independently supervising the radiological safety of the crew and for daily sampling, recording, and reporting of Reactor Chemistry to the Command. I saw inefficiencies in manually creating the required documentation so I started learning Excel formulas and VBA to help automate the data analytics and reporting. Within my first year, I was honored as Junior Sailor of the Quarter for boosting the morale of the crews of a visiting Australian submarine and my ship, while excelling in my managerial abilities.

After my time in the Navy, I returned home and started college majoring in Material Science and Engineering. During my time at college I was inducted into an Engineering Honorary and earned a Student Leadership award for my work with student organizations honoring US and Allied Veteran Students and Faculty.

While in college I joined the opening crew of a local casino as a Poker Dealer. Within 3 months I was promoted to a Floor Supervisor for my leadership and support of the other dealers. I was responsible for improving the efficiency of the day to day operations of the largest Poker Room in the State of Ohio, as well as observing the laws and regulations enforced by the Ohio Casino Control Commission (OCCC). In one case I got approval from the OCCC to save the casino \$2000 a month with a cardboard box. I also started building an application to log and record dealer performance, which provided consistency and impartialness to the existing process. Around this time it became clear that my professional journey was leading me to towards Software Development. I transferred to a technical college with a major in Web Application Development by the start of the next quarter.

It was in my programming classes that I started to see several parallels between my experiences in skilled trades and software development. While most people may look at complex woodwork in awe, I see the individual joints that are elegantly layered together. I learned the value of breaking bigger problems into smaller ones very early on in my career. For example, as a junior carpenter, I was able to build a complex handrail the day after the crew's Lead Carpenter had declared "impossible" to build after 2 days of trying and failing. My success came from tackling the complexity of the handrails by building it one joint at a time. The same is true for developing solutions in software, the framework and gems become the "tools" used to craft each connection in the code's logic.

Not only has my entire career path led me to the Software Developer that I am today, but it has also primed me to be successful on Small Teams³ and proficient as a Manager of One¹. From being on small or solo carpentry crews, to being in a division of at most five people amongst a crew of 150+, to being one of five Floor Supervisor in the Poker Room with 150+ dealers and now as a developer that has worked independently and on teams as large as 300+, I have found the most success coming from the smaller teams that encouraged me to collaborate with them while also trusting me to working independently.

Thank you for considering the opportunity of me joining your team at 37Signals,

Footnotes

1. [Manager of One](#)
2. [Columbus Ruby Brigade](#)
4. [Senior Rails Programmer Role](#)
5. [Junior Rails Programmer Role](#)
6. [Programming & Software Development Program](#)

Signals

3. [Small Teams](#)
28. [Shots on Goal](#)

Michael Newman